

Shari's Week 0 Day 7 Unincluded Vital Sign Report

Oxygen Saturation (SpO₂)

Oxygen saturation (SpO₂) measures the percentage of haemoglobin in the blood that is carrying oxygen. It is usually checked with a pulse oximeter placed on the finger, toe or earlobe. SpO₂ should be included in triage because it gives a quick idea of how well a patient is oxygenating and can help identify breathing problems early. For most healthy people, a normal SpO₂ is about 95-100%. In acutely ill adults who are not at risk of hypercapnic respiratory failure, the usual target range is around 94-98%. However, patients with conditions such as COPD may have a lower target range of 88-92%, because giving too much oxygen can worsen carbon dioxide retention. Low SpO₂ may indicate hypoxaemia and can be linked to conditions such as asthma attacks, pneumonia, pulmonary embolism, heart failure or shock. In triage, this is important because a patient with low oxygen levels may need urgent assessment, oxygen therapy, respiratory support, or escalation of care. At the same time, a reading of 100% should not always be taken as fully reassuring, especially if the patient is already receiving oxygen. Some patients can also have silent hypoxia, where their oxygen level is dangerously low even though they do not look severely distressed. For this reason, SpO₂ should always be interpreted alongside respiratory rate, work of breathing, heart rate, mental status and the patient's overall clinical condition.